

Main

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

African Leadership Academy_South Africa_2022-23_3-month report

Fellowship Organization

African Leadership Academy (ALA)

Fellowship City

Johannesburg

Fellowship Country

South Africa

Fellowship Start Date

08/15/2022

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

07/31/2021

What is your fellowship title/role?

Special Projects Fellow

What are your primary responsibilities?

Manage several projects include foreign payment solutions to simplify financial transactions / Collaborate with team members to manage forecast season and other departments

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Agree

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

No

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.
If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?

No, I did not receive any kind of orientation. I am continuously learning on the job. I was given my projects and people to whom I could contact for clarification.

Describe a representative day at work.

Work typically starts at 8am and I check my emails until the weekly finance meeting at 8:30am. Afterwards I attend to the business of the day. There is usually a snack break between 10am and 3pm. I close typically at 5pm.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

40-45 hrs

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Effective

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

(1) Endowment management and ensuring funds were received in a timely manner through preparing notarized KYC documents (2) attend proposal meetings for solar power project and document key takeaways for executive analysis

What is your organization's work culture like?
What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.

I work at a school campus (boarding school type of environment), but more specifically in the administration building. My team comprises 10 people and we complete our work in the finance office.

To whom do you report?

CFO and I work on Endowment management, investment committee, and solar powers. Financial Manager and I don't work directly on a day to day, but I have 3 focal projects I received at the beginning of my fellowship.

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

No

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?
Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.

I have met with my supervisor, but there is no official work plan in place. This may change in the coming months, but I am unsure.

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.

(1) Streamline foreign payment solutions and reduce the manual input required to execute the payment process. (2) Attend 2 professional development opportunities and build my network inside and outside the school (3) Speak more in meetings and share my thoughts and ideas

Do you receive adequate direction/support to perform your fellowship responsibilities?
Please provide more information on your response above.

My goal is to sharpen my soft and technical skill sets.

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Weekly

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

No

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response.

Based on my previous experiences, I get to utilize the skills and knowledge acquired in my current day to day. I am focused on banking and investment workflows which allows me to utilize my knowledge from working in the asset management space.

Life at Fellowship Site

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

I purchased my ticket to Johannesburg, South Africa through Delta airlines and was originally scheduled to fly from Washington DC to Atlanta to Johannesburg directly. However, my flight was delayed due to severe weather and ended up flying from Washington DC to Atlanta to Amsterdam to Johannesburg. I bought a one way ticket the month of for \$1,200.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

I applied for a voluntary visa

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

I am still in the process of obtaining my visa.

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

No, but there is a visa on arrival for 90 days.

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

Approximately \$100

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

I paid, but the organization covers it.

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

Yes

If yes, please explain further

The process has been delayed due to COVID; the offices have a backlog of applications.

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

I would suggest applying for a visa as soon as you know your post. I'm not sure if it was because of Covid, but the process was extended and quite difficult. Everything from scheduling an appointment

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

There were not any requirements besides the COVID-19 vaccine required by PiAf. I got yellow-fever, but it was not required by my country.

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

My arrival was a little bit more hectic than I expected. I landed Thursday evening and started working the following Monday. Jet lag impacted me and my energy levels. I would suggest arriving at least 5-7 days prior to the start date to give your body time to adjust.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

Yes, my housing was provided for my organization. This was part of my offers and I do not have to pay for it

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Somewhat Urban (Suburban)

Please describe your living environment

I live in a golf estate with a security gate that requires a unique code to access. Very walkable and has amenities such as a pool, gym, and eating.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

Uber; R100 (approximately \$5.89 daily and it is 10 minutes to get to work if there isn't any traffic

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

N/A

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

Summer; the weather varies. Sometimes it's very hot, sometimes it rains, thunder while the sun is out.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

Business casual and casual clothing. Dress attire is flexible and presentable outside of work.

How have you been spending your free time?

During the weekdays, I generally do not do much, but during the weekend I try to engage in different cultural activities. Since I have been here, I have gone to festivals, ballet, plays, and so much more. My goal is to take advantage of the opportunity of things I would not normally have the time or resources to do.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Disagree

Please briefly explain your response below.

Disagree - it's a bit more complicated managing the time difference and holidays missed.

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

Yes

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

I walk around with my pepper spray for my safety. I think it is better to have it and not need it, then not to have it and need it. I have not had to use it, and I am grateful for that

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

There has been no experience with crime and I am highly grateful for that.

N/A

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

Currently, I am unable to see my original goals from before orientation, but I would state that I am actively trying to be present in my experience.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

Generally, I would say things are well.

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

I don't believe so

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

I do not think I have experience much "cultural shock" since I have been here and it has been easy to acclimate to my new environment

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

The convenience of things has been the most surprising. I often compare my experience to living in another state but with the exposure of a different culture. Most cities are generally metropolitan and that is my experience here as well. I did not expect to have such easy access to everything I could possibly want whether it is food or experiences.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

I would say transition from working from home to working onsite Monday through Friday has actually been more challenging than expected. I miss the flexibility of working from home, and there are some days where I am exhausted from office culture, but I must still be present, which is not always the easiest thing to do.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

I miss being able to drive around and go places whenever I wanted. I miss Trader Joes and buying plantain chips or seaweed or just the atmosphere of the store. Lastly, I miss being able to take spontaneous trips without having to actively plan.

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

(1) The affordability of things is absolutely amazing. I bought a last minute ticket to the ballet for less than \$50 and I sat in the front row. It was absolutely an amazing experience I would not have been able to do in the states. (2) Nature/Wildlife - Game safaris (3) Food

How is your stipend being paid?

A. Monthly B. U.S. dollars C. U.S. account

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

Wire

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

No, I did not, but I worked prior to starting my fellowship and I set money aside before starting.

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent	Utilities	Furnishings	Phone	Home Security	Internet
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00
Transportation	Fitness	Entertainment	Groceries	House Cleaning	Eating Out
\$120.00	\$15.00	\$200.00	\$20.00	\$30.00	\$300.00
Medications	Additional Health Insurance	Travel	Laundry	Other	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel)
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$300.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	485.00
Specify "Other"					

Final Thoughts

PiAf's orientation was sufficient in preparing me to transition into my fellowship.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

Orientation prepared me as much as an orientation could do so. Because there are so many experiences, I think the approach of highlighting resources and possible scenarios is probably the best that could be done.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

There is nothing I could think of.

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

Transition back into life in the US